



SparkHacks

★ 2026 ★

Welcome!

Meet Your Directors!



Naga Maddipudi

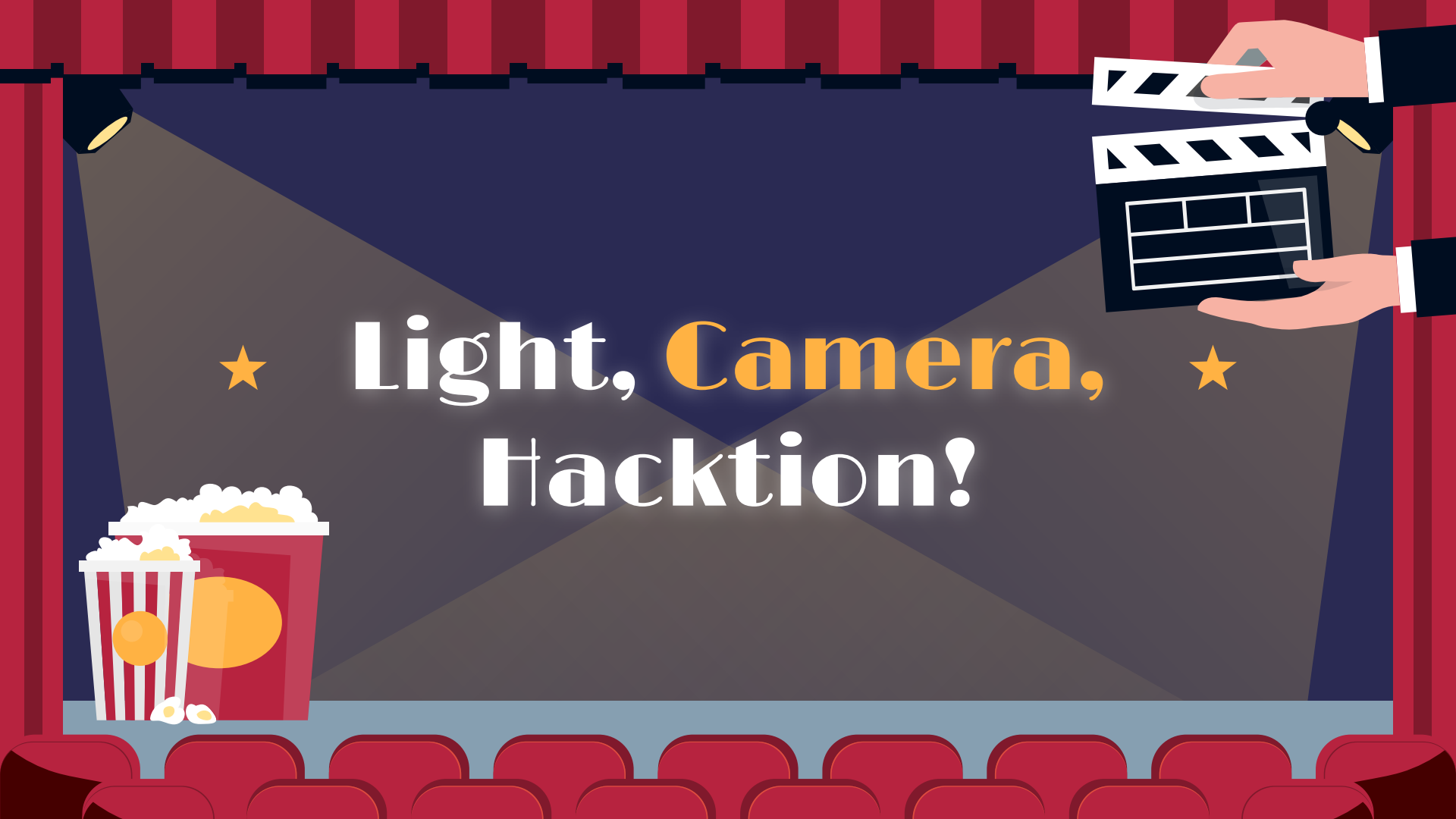


Kaito Sekiya

The background of the poster is a dark blue stage with red curtains on the left and right. A red carpet leads from the bottom left towards a golden trophy. Two spotlights on the floor cast beams of light across the stage. The trophy is a large, multi-pointed star on a tiered base. The text 'SparkHacks' is in white and '2026' is in orange.

SparkHacks 2026

SparkHacks is UIC's one and only student-led hackathon in its fourth year, bringing students together to learn, collaborate, and compete!



★ Light, Camera, ★
Hacktion!

Code of Conduct



All university rules apply to this event!



Be respectful to everyone around you!



No tolerance for any harassment!



Respect the space & clean up!



Collaborate towards a fair competition!



Do not spam in the Discord channels!



**No food inside work rooms!
Covered drinks are fine!**



Disqualification

S



Participating without official acceptance



Reusing or extending past projects or templates



**Working outside approved areas
(CDRLC Floors 1, 2 only)**



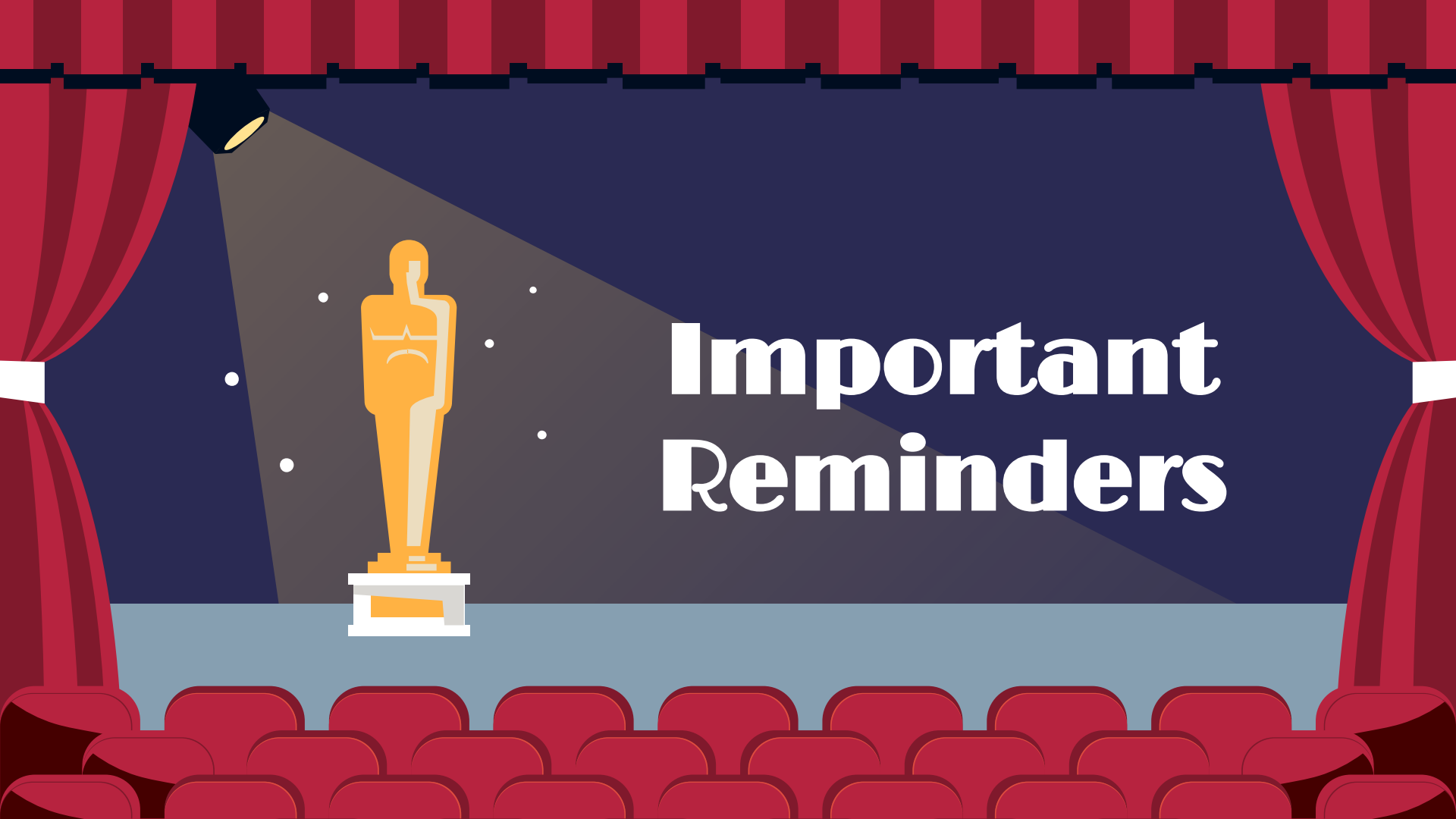
Eating inside classrooms



Not following hackathon rules or staff instructions

If you're unsure — ask an organizer first.





Important Reminders



HackPack



Discord

The HackPack has ALL the information you will need!

DIRECTOR



The **Best Ways** to Ask for Help!

Ask specific questions
instead of asking for
direct answers 🙋

Break down you
problems into
smaller parts 🎯

Look up online for
resources to debug code
and troubleshoot issues



How to Find Organizers?



VIP lanyards



Professional attire on Day 1



Black SparkHacks sweatshirts
on Day 2

How Can You Get Assisted?

01

In-Person Support

Mentors wearing black lanyards are walking around the work rooms so ask for help!

Mentor room: CDRLC 1402A

02

Help Forum

Ask questions in the **ask-a-mentor**  forum on Discord!

03

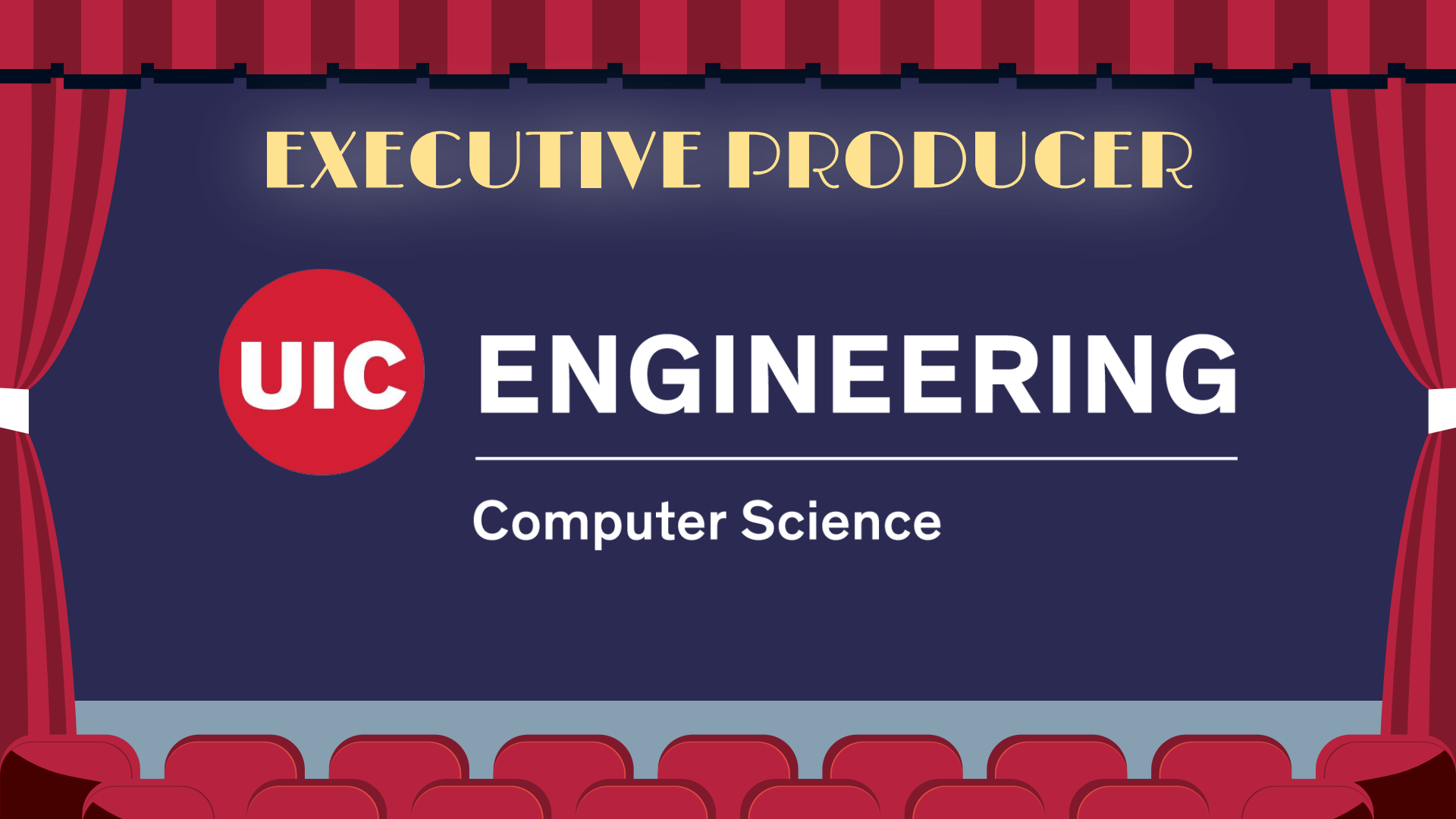
Help Desk

Need help? Stop by the Help Desk anytime!

CDRLC Room 1413 (Check-in & Food)

Let's
meet our
Sponsors!





EXECUTIVE PRODUCER



ENGINEERING

Computer Science





LEADING STAR

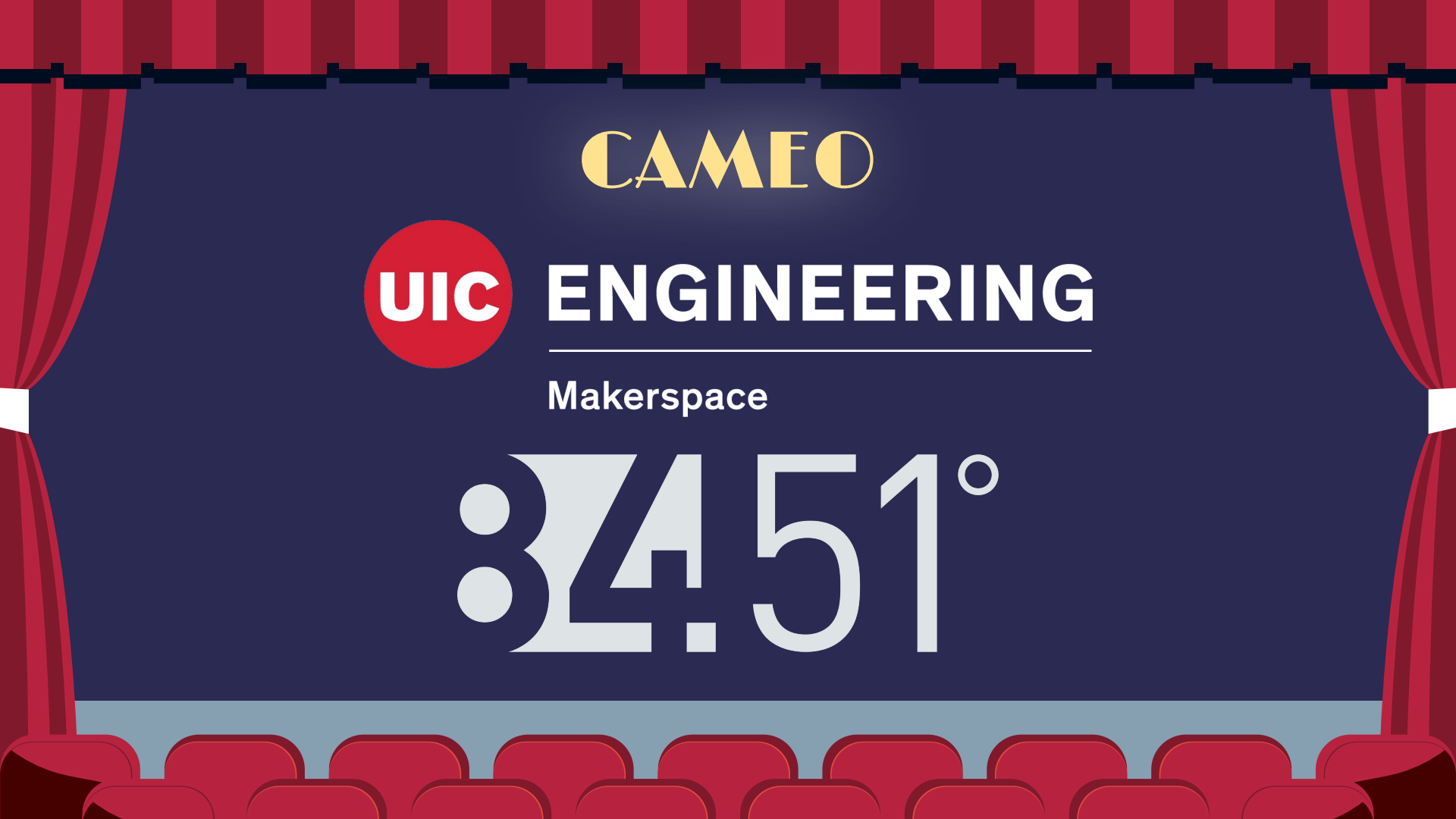
GRAINGER®

FOR THE ONES WHO GET IT DONE

Supporting Cast



CME Group



CAMEO

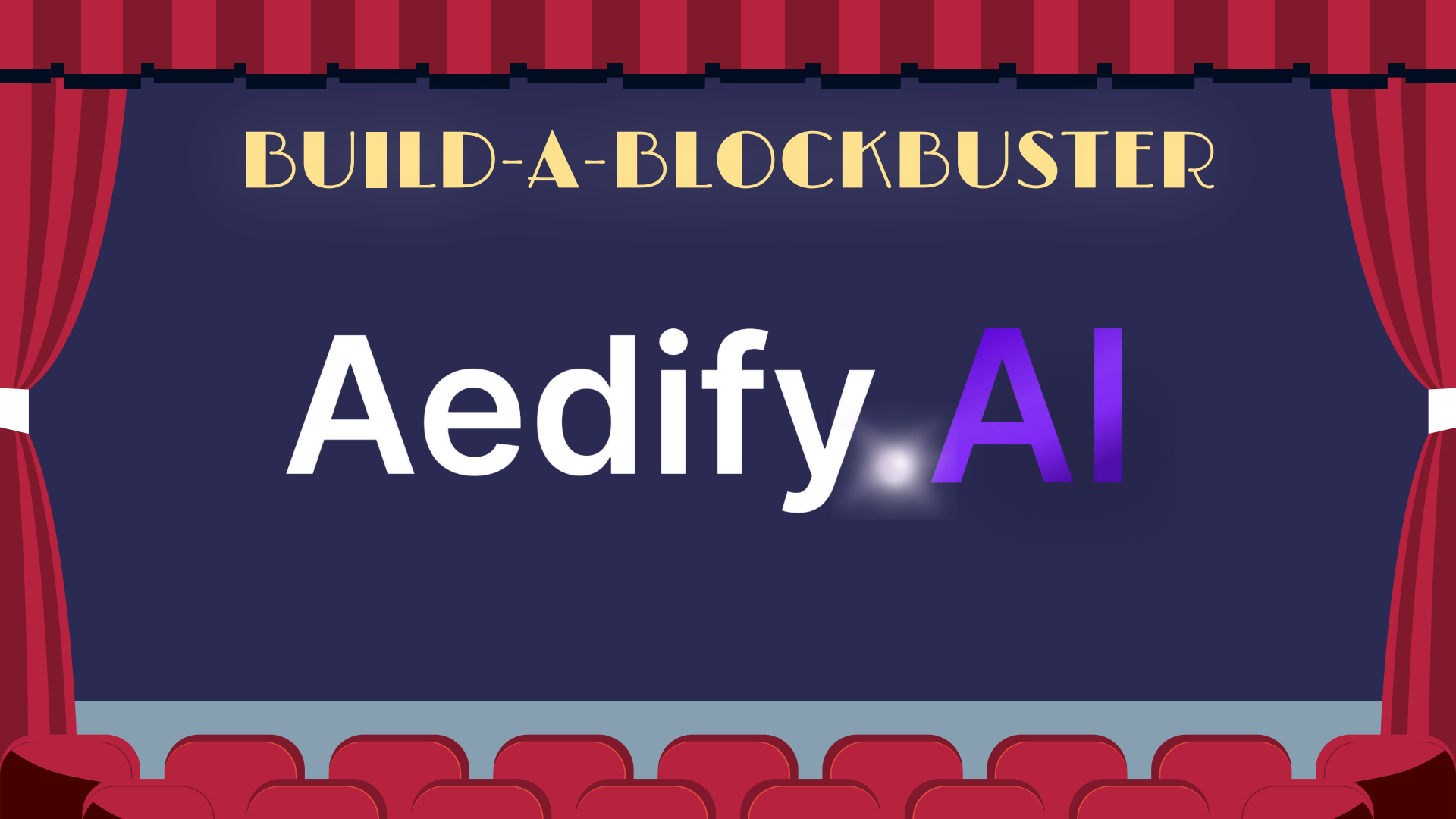


ENGINEERING

Makerspace

34.51°



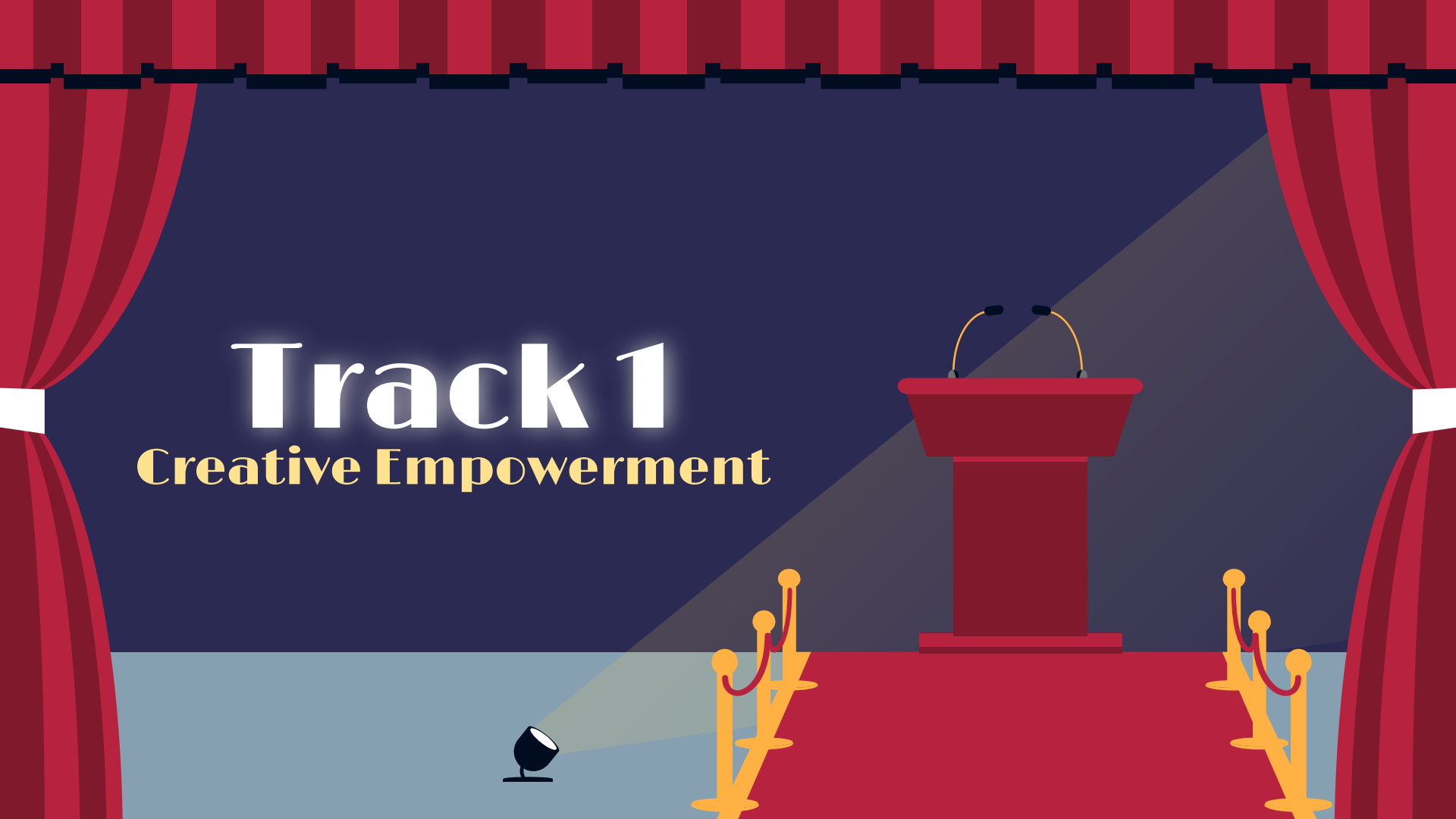
The background of the image is a stylized theater stage. At the top, there are red curtains with a dark blue horizontal band across them. The main stage area is a dark blue rectangle. At the bottom, there are rows of red theater seats. The text "BUILD-A-BLOCKBUSTER" is written in a yellow, serif font across the top of the stage. The text "Aedify AI" is written in a large, white, sans-serif font in the center of the stage, with the "AI" part in a vibrant purple color.

BUILD-A-BLOCKBUSTER

Aedify AI

SparkHacks 2026 Tracks!



The background is a stylized stage. At the top, there are red curtains with white ties. The main background is a dark blue gradient. On the right, there is a red podium with two microphones. A spotlight from the bottom left illuminates the podium and the text. In the foreground, there is a red carpet leading to the podium, flanked by yellow stanchions with red ropes. A small black spotlight is on the floor to the left.

Track 1

Creative Empowerment

Track 1: Creative Empowerment

Propose a technological solution that empowers emerging creators to showcase their work, connect with collaborators, and grow an audience 🎬

This may involve building digital platforms or AI tools that help independent actors, directors, and scriptwriters overcome discovery, collaboration, and monetization barriers. Examples include fair creator-discovery systems, collaboration-matching tools, or new ways for small creators to reach the right audience without relying on large algorithms 🤖👤✨



Track 2

Narrative Storytelling in an Interactive Application

Track 2: Narrative Storytelling in an Interactive Application

Create an interactive application that tells a compelling, immersive story and makes users feel part of the narrative 📖✨

This could involve a UI-driven storytelling app that explores meaningful real-world themes through user choice, with a focus on polished design, emotional engagement, and a handful of impactful decisions.

Not just a story—an experience. Build narratives users can step into and explore 🚪📖

The background is a stylized stage scene. At the top, there are red curtains with a dark blue valance. Two large spotlights from the top cast a beam of light down towards the center. The stage floor is light blue, and a red carpet with yellow side lines leads from the bottom center towards the text. Two small black stage lights are on the floor at the bottom corners.

Track 3

Shop Savvy with Crainger

GRAINGER®

FOR THE ONES WHO GET IT DONE

Track 3: Shop Savvy with Crainger

Create a data and AI-driven tool 🤖📊 that enhances purchasing and anticipates customer needs, improving the customer experience through useful ✨ and timely suggestions.

Make buying smarter, faster, and more effortless—turn complex purchasing into confident decisions ⚡🛒

Special Challenge

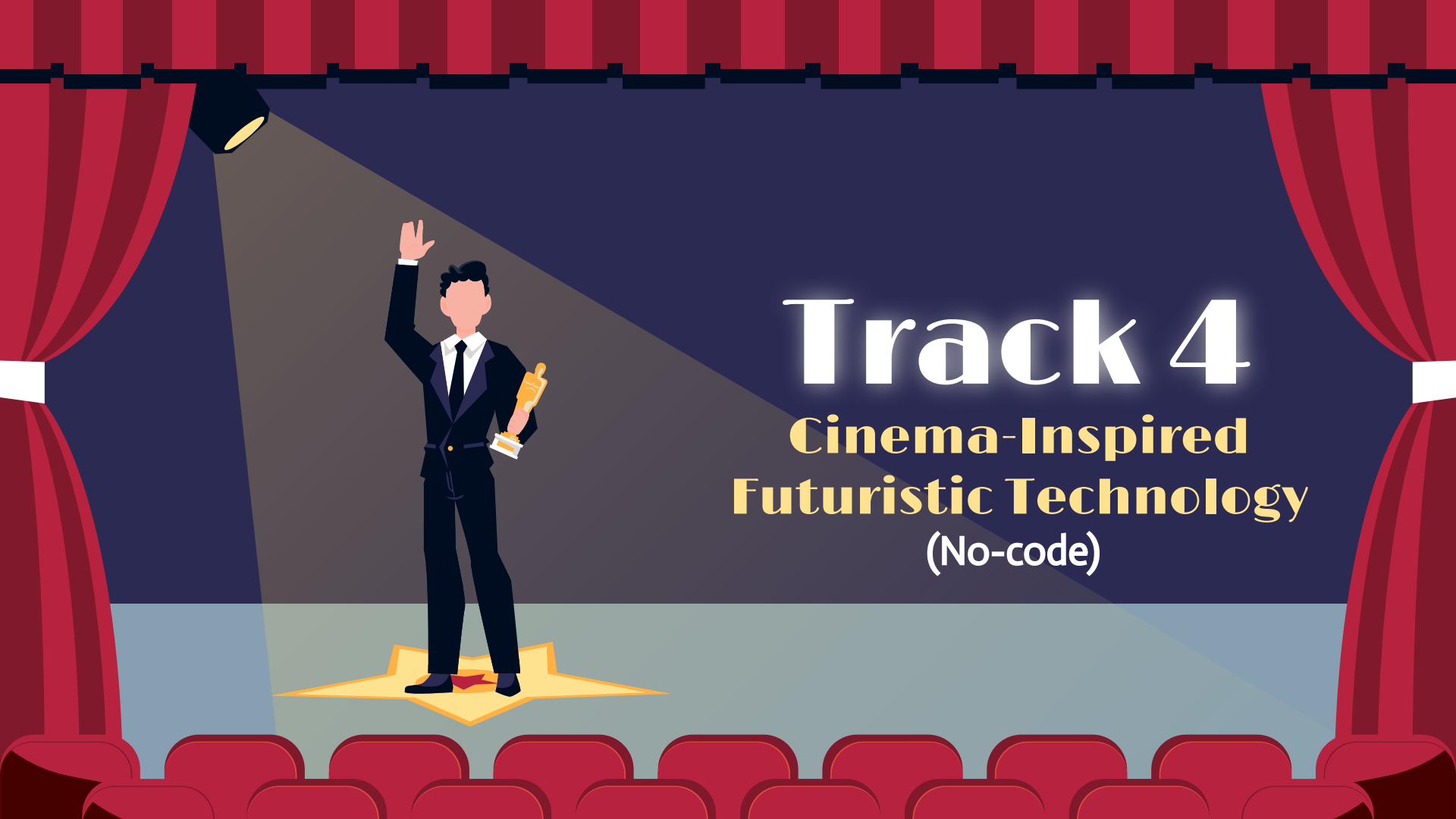
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FOR THE ONES WHO GET IT DONE

🏆 **Best User Experience Design**

For those competing in the Grainger track: Create a clean, accessible interface that's easy to navigate for users of all age groups.





Track 4

**Cinema-Inspired
Futuristic Technology**
(No-code)

Track 4: Cinema-Inspired Futuristic Technology

Create or enhance a futuristic technology that could be inspired by film, focusing on concept, design, and imagination rather than code 🎬✨

This could involve reimagining technologies from films—such as futuristic interfaces or speculative devices—through visual design, user flows, and interactive mockups to explore how they might exist in the real world or enhance the story they came from.

No code. No limits. Just imagination. Bring movie technology to life through design and creativity 🎥🚀

Sponsor Special Challenges



Special Challenge

Aedify AI

🏆 Best Deployed on Aedify

Create a novel project that best utilizes Aedify's deployment and infrastructure resources. It must be successfully deployed with a live, external domain and it must be functional!



Submission Overview

01



Draft Submission

(Google Form due 2:30 PM Saturday)

- Select your **track**
- Enter your **finalized** project name
- List **team member** names

02



Final Submission (Devpost)

- Submit your project on **SparkHacks 2026 Devpost** including:
 - Project name & team members
 - Project description
 - Required materials based on your track (code repo + demo OR no-code prototype)
 - 2 min long max video of your project!



**Now what everyone has
been waiting for...**

Prizes!

winners announced at Closing Ceremony! 💰

Track 1 Prizes: Creative Empowerment / Digital Storytelling



1st Place

Amazon Fire HD 8 Tablet
(8" Display, 32GB)



2nd Place

4K Digital Camera
(64MP, Dual Lens, Anti-Shake)



3rd Place

Logitech Wave Keys Ergonomic
Wireless Keyboard

Track 2 Prizes: Narrative Storytelling in an Interactive Application



1st Place

Toshiba 40" V35 Series FHD
Smart Fire TV (2025)



2nd Place

Sony WH-CH520 Wireless
Headphones



3rd Place

Fitbit Fitness Tracker

Track 3 Prizes: Shop Savvy with Crainger



1st Place

Insignia™ 32" F20 Series
HD Smart Fire TV



2nd Place

Amazon Echo Dot Max
(Newest Model)



3rd Place

LEMBERI Ergonomic Gaming Chair
with Footrest

Track 4 Prizes: Cinema-Inspired Futuristic Technology



1st Place

5 fun & unique LEGO sets!



Sponsor Special Challenges

Crainger



JBL Tune 245NC Noise-Canceling
Earbuds (5 winners)

Aedify



Apple AirTag (4 Pack)
(5 winners, one pack per person)

Mini-Challenges!

 **Sponsor Expo Raffle
(Friday)**



Acer Portable Monitor PM161Q

 **Count the Kernels**



White Echo Dot

 **Find the Oscars
(Saturday)**



JBL GO 3

Workshops

**AI Infrastructure with
Aedify**



Next.js and Vite

**Intro to Deep Learning &
Neural Networks w/ Argonne
Researcher**



Python and Keras

SparkHacks 2026



DAY 1 SCHEDULE

FRIDAY, FEB. 6TH, 2026

CHECK IN

CDRLC 1413
4:00-7:30PM

Have your QR code ready and get your teammates together for check-in.

OPENING CEREMONY

SES 250
5:30-6:00PM

Join us for the big night!
We'll introduce our sponsors, reveal
the tracks, and prizes.

SPONSOR TABLING

CDRLC ATRIUM
4:30-7:30PM

This is your chance to network
with our AWESOME sponsors in a
casual environment.

AEDIFY WORKSHOP

CDRLC 1426
6:30-7:30PM

Join our wonderful sponsor Aedify
for their block-buster workshop!

ARGONNE WORKSHOP

CDRLC 1426
7:30-8:30PM

Join our amazing sponsor Argonne
for their block-buster workshop!

DINNER

CDRLC 1413
8:00-9:00PM

Enjoy some top tier food!
Vegetarian options available.

DE-STRESS: MARIO KART!

CDRLC 2411
8:00-9:00PM

Take a breather, compete with friends
in Mario Kart, and enjoy some
midnight snacks!

LIGHTS, CAMERA, HACKTION!

SparkHacks 2026



DAY 2 SCHEDULE

SATURDAY, FEB. 7TH, 2026

CHECK IN

CDRLC 1413
9:00-10:00AM

Check in for Day 2 and re-fuel with breakfast! Vegetarian options available.

LUNCH

CDRLC 1413
1:00-2:00PM

It's the final stretch! Make sure to grab food with your team before your final submission.

DEVPOST DRAFT DUE!

2:30PM

Make sure drafts for DevPosts have been made and teams have been submitted!

DESTRESS: CHARADES!

CDRLC 1426
3:00-5:00PM

Unwind and enjoy a game of charades with your fellow hackers!

HACKING OVER!

5:30PM

YOU DID IT! FINAL SUBMISSIONS!
NO LATE POSTS ALLOWED.

PROJECT EXPO

CDRLC
6:00-7:00PM

Showcase your projects to our sponsors while judging takes place.

DINNER & MEET THE TEAM

CDRLC 1426
7:00-8:00PM

Enjoy your well-earned dinner! Vegetarian options available.
+ Meet the SparkHacks team!

CLOSING CEREMONY

SES 250
8:15-8:45PM

Winner announcements, awards, and closing remarks!



Event Schedule

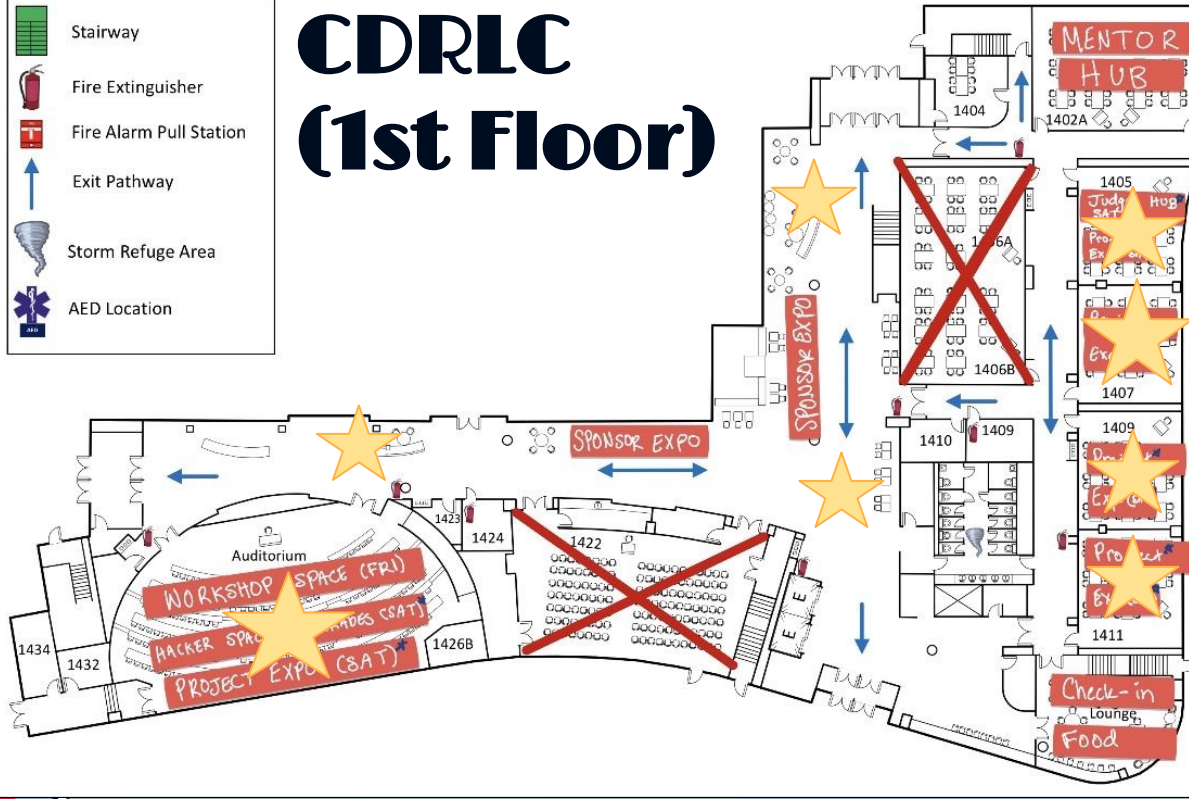


Room Schedules

Room schedules has all the details.
scan the QR to find an open space to work!



CDRLC (1st Floor)



Available hacker spaces are marked with **stars** on the map :
 CDRLC Atrium, 1405, 1407, 1409, 1411, 2402, 2403, 2406A, 2406B, 2405, 2407, 2409, 2411, Auditorium*

- Rooms with an asterisk* are not available to hackers **after 5:30 PM on Saturday, February 7th.**
- 1405 is not available **after 4:30PM on Saturday, February 7th.**
- The Auditorium is **ONLY** available to hackers **on Saturday before 5:30 PM.**
- Hackers are free to use the Atrium seating spaces.

CDRLC (2nd Floor)

 Stairway

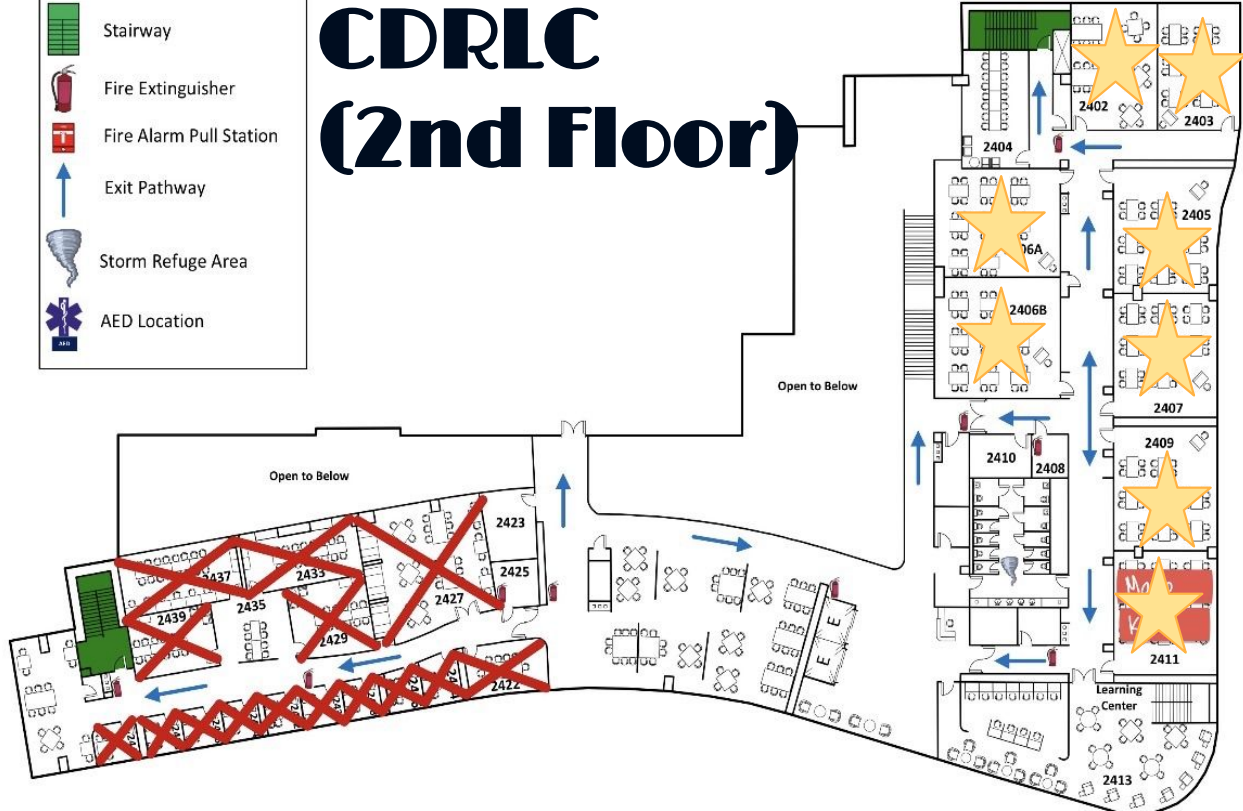
 Fire Extinguisher

 Fire Alarm Pull Station

 Exit Pathway

 Storm Refuge Area

 AED Location



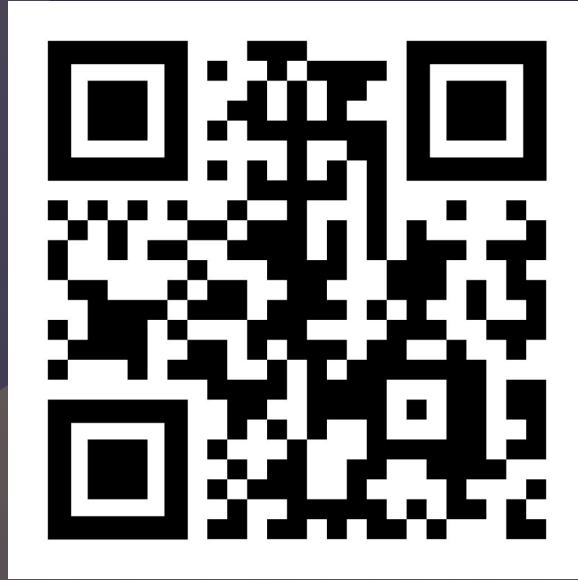
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Food Distribution

- ★ Food will be released **in batches**
- ★ Each batch will be **announced on Discord**
- ★ Please wait for your group's announcement
before lining up

Food & Allergy Information



Food details and allergy information are available in the document



Housekeeping & Reminders



No food on the second floor at all . Covered drinks are fine.



Floors 3, 4, and 5 are **off limits** .



Please help keep our building clean!





Light, Camera, Hacktion!

Press record, your hackathon starts now!